AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Putting the Team Working Standard into Practice

How do I make the standard actually stick?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 5 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Action lesson · 6–8 min

THE CORE IDEA

A standard only matters when it changes behavior.

It becomes real the first time you reference it in real work, it sticks because you keep referencing it, and one quarterly question keeps it current.

1 Complete is not active

Most standards fail right at completion — not because they were wrong, but because the manager treated completion as adoption: the document existed, the work felt done, the work went back to normal. The step between complete and real is **activation** — not a second event, but a small set of moves made from completion onward. Making them, or skipping them, decides whether the standard holds or drifts.

2 Three ways a completed standard fails

It becomes invisible

Saved in a shared folder, linked once, never mentioned again. Technically available — but nothing in daily work surfaces it. Within a month, asking about it would feel like a quiz.

It stays manager-held

Only the manager remembers it or interprets what applies. When a new situation comes up, the team waits to be told what the standard says instead of using it as a shared reference.

It goes stale

This one arrives by time, not neglect. Tools change, tasks evolve — six months later the standard still names the previous tool, and people adjust individually: the exact fragmentation the standard was built to prevent.

All three are preventable — through activation, and one recurring check.

3 Activation: three elements

First, place it where work happens — pinned in the team's main channel, linked in the project tool. Not in a folder; in the flow. This prevents the invisibility failure.

Second, name how it will be used — a short framing that positions the document as a working tool, not a policy, and gives the team explicit permission to flag problems. That permission prevents the manager-held failure.

Third, use it in the work — and keep using it. The element the first two exist for, and the one most managers skip. An announcement tells the team the standard exists; a **reference** tells them it applies — to real work, in a real decision. Bring it in at the live moments the work hands you — a review, a handoff, a one-to-one — and ask

how it applies. The first reference starts the habit; consistent reference turns the standard into infrastructure. (Catching every error is the Checkpoint Map's job, next module.)

TWO SENTENCES THAT DO THE WORK

1. **Naming the shift:** *"This is now our shared standard for how we work with AI. We'll use it in reviews, handoffs, onboarding, and whenever something is unclear. If something comes up that it doesn't cover, or something in it stops working, bring it to me. We'll update it."*
2. **Referencing it in live work:** *"Our standard says anything going to a client gets a human read-through. Walk me through your review here."*

4 Keeping the standard current

The whole maintenance mechanism is one question, once a quarter: *"Is anything in this standard no longer working, unclear, or outdated?"* Five minutes at the end of a team meeting. If yes, update; if no, move on – the date at the top changes, and the team knows it's current.

A revisit comes sooner when a **new AI tool** arrives or an existing one changes significantly, the **team's work changes** – new clients, task types, or risk areas – or a **re-run of the AI Baseline Assessment** shows the standard is no longer followed in practice.

One distinction: the quarterly check handles **collective drift**. One person consistently working outside the standard is a coaching conversation – later, under Lead – not a standard failure.

5 What you've built

Align has kept its promise. Assess gave you the picture – the **Team AI Baseline** – and Align turned it into the **Team Working Standard**, agreed with your team where before each person decided alone. That foundation is what the rest of the course builds on. Next: keeping the work safe, with checkpoints that catch problems before they reach a client or a decision.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Put the standard **in the flow of work**, not in a folder.
- Name the shift out loud once – working tool, not policy, with permission to flag problems.
- Reference the standard in live work – the first reference starts the habit, repetition makes it infrastructure.
- Ask the one quarterly question and change the date at the top.
- Collective drift updates the standard; individual drift is a coaching conversation for later.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working – the module that turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. Download with this lesson: Handout D – Quarterly Review. **Next: Module 4, Lesson 4.1 – When AI Errors Become Business Decisions** – the Control move begins: putting checks where the risk enters the work.